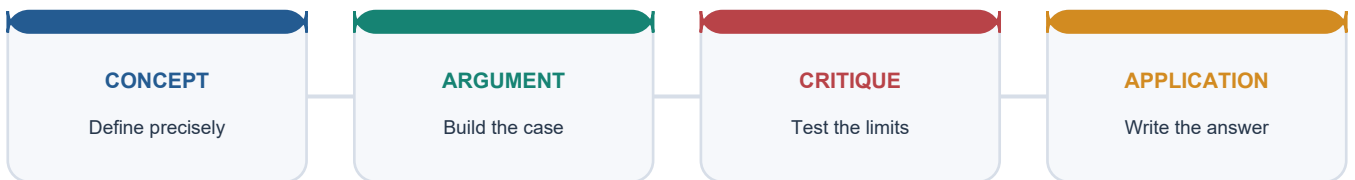


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Languages, Scripts, Literature and Manuscripts - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC standalone solved workbook | full-Markdown render path | MCQs, PYQs and model answers

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

Languages, Scripts, Literature and Manuscripts - Solved Practice Workbook

This standalone workbook carries exactly 32 original MCQs with strict ABCD rotation, 4 objective/application PYQs, 1 cross-owned direct/application Mains PYQ and 6 full original Mains answers.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

CORE UPSC MCQS

Q1. Which statement is the safest opening for an Indian-language answer?

A. Language family, script, register and legal-cultural status should be treated as separate classifications before examples are added. B. Every Indian script corresponds to exactly one language family. C. Classical-language status and Eighth Schedule status are interchangeable labels. D. Religious community can usually be inferred directly from script choice.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct because category separation is the first safety rule of the topic. B and C falsely merge different classifications, while D communalises a linguistic fact that the sources explicitly treat more cautiously.

Q2. Which pair correctly belongs to the major language-family map used in this topic?

A. Grantha and Sharada B. Indo-Aryan and Dravidian C. Article 343 and the Eighth Schedule D. Nastaliq and Modi

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct because Indo-Aryan and Dravidian are language families. A and D are scripts, while C contains constitutional categories rather than language families.

Q3. Which statement best preserves the relation between Sanskrit and Prakrit?

A. Prakrit is simply a corrupted form of Sanskrit and requires no further qualification. B. Sanskrit disappeared before Prakrit literature expanded. C. Sanskrit and Prakrit functioned in overlapping literary and social domains; coexistence is safer than a degeneration story. D. Prakrit can never be linked to Buddhist or Jain textual worlds.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct. A turns an old value judgement into fact, B invents a clean replacement chronology, and D ignores Pali, Ardhamagadhi and other Prakrit-linked traditions in Buddhist and Jain literature.

Q4. Which statement about Pali and Ardhamagadhi is safest?

A. Both labels can be used as certain audio records of exactly what the Buddha and Mahavira spoke every day. B. Pali belongs only to courtly Sanskrit kavya. C. Ardhamagadhi has no Jain connection in the source bank. D. Pali is tied to the Theravada canonical field, while Ardhamagadhi is important to Jain textual tradition; actual speech history remains more complex.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct because it keeps both the association and the qualification. A overstates certainty, B misplaces Pali, and C erases a major Jain link.

Q5. Which statement about Ashokan inscriptions is safest?

A. They are mostly in Prakrit and Brahmi, with Kharoshthi in the north-west and Greek-Aramaic examples in the frontier zone. B. They are all in Sanskrit and Devanagari. C. They prove that Harappan script was already deciphered in the Mauryan age. D. They were the first modern printed editions of Indian literature.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct and covers the major inscriptional distribution. B is the classic prelims trap, C invents a relation to Harappan decipherment, and D confuses inscriptions with print history.

Q6. Which statement about Kharoshthi is correct?

A. It was the standard script for all south Indian temple walls. B. It was mostly written right-to-left and is especially associated with the north-western zone. C. It is another name for Grantha. D. It is a modern alphabet created in 1925 for Santali.

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct. A wrongly relocates Kharoshthi to the south, C merges unrelated scripts, and D describes Ol Chiki instead.

Q7. Which chronology is safest for Sanskrit grammar and datable Sanskrit epigraphy?

A. James Prinsep composed the Ashtadhyayi and Rudradaman deciphered it in 1837. B. The earliest Sanskrit inscription is the Harappan seal corpus. C. Panini systematised Sanskrit grammar long before the earliest extensive datable Sanskrit inscription at Junagarh under Rudradaman I. D. Junagarh proves that all early inscriptions in India were Sanskrit.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because Panini's grammatical system belongs to an earlier horizon than Rudradaman I's Junagarh inscription, which is an inscriptional milestone rather than the birth of Sanskrit itself. A and C reverse people or periods, while D falsely universalises one inscriptional example.

Q8. Which statement about the Chebrolu inscription is safest for this topic?

A. It is the same as the Gwalior zero inscription of 876 CE. B. It proves every South Indian literary text was written in Sanskrit. C. It belongs to the undeciphered Harappan corpus. D. It is treated in the source bank as the earliest datable South Indian Sanskrit inscription, issued in 207 CE and discovered in 2019.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct because the keyed statement identifies Chebrolu exactly as the topic bank uses it: a datable South Indian Sanskrit inscription of 207 CE, discovered in 2019. The remaining options confuse it with unrelated inscriptions or misplace it into Harappan archaeology.

Q9. Which statement about Vatteluttu and Grantha is safest?

A. Vatteluttu served southern writing traditions, while the Pallava court later preferred Grantha for its own scribal-cultural purposes. B. Vatteluttu and Grantha are two names for the same modern Hindi script. C. Grantha was created only for Urdu poetry. D. Vatteluttu is a constitutional category under Article 343.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct because it preserves the useful court-level distinction: Vatteluttu belonged to southern writing practice, while Pallava-Grantha became important in Pallava court usage. The other options confuse scripts with languages or constitutional categories.

Q10. Which statement about Grantha is correct?

A. It is the oldest undeciphered script of Harappan seals. B. It was widely used in the Tamil-Kerala zone to write Sanskrit and Manipravalam and is historically linked to Malayalam's script development. C. It was standardised by Guru Angad for the Guru Granth Sahib. D. It is a true alphabet invented in 1925 by Raghunath Murmu.

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct. A describes Harappan script, C describes Gurmukhi, and D describes Ol Chiki.

Q11. Which pair is correctly matched?

A. Sharada - modern shorthand script for Marathi revenue writing B. Modi - dedicated 1925 alphabet for Santali C. Gurmukhi - standardised in the 16th century by Guru Angad D. Ol Chiki - south Indian Sanskrit copper-plate script of Vijayanagara

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because Gurmukhi is linked to standardisation by Guru Angad in the 16th century. The other pairs confuse Sharada, Modi and Ol Chiki with functions or periods that do not belong to them.

Q12. Which statement about Ol Chiki is safest?

A. It is simply another name for Devanagari. B. It is a late-medieval Perso-Arabic hand used for Urdu poetry. C. It was created for Sanskrit manuscripts of Vijayanagara copper plates. D. It was created in 1925 by Raghunath Murmu for Santali and is treated as a true alphabet rather than an abugida.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct. A and B collapse it into unrelated scripts, while C confuses it with Nandinagari-style manuscript usage.

Q13. Which statement about manuscripts is safest?

A. Ancient Indian manuscripts were often made on palm leaves and had to be recopied repeatedly because of fragility. B. Manuscripts in India were always printed books from the beginning. C. Palm-leaf manuscripts could not carry commentary around the main text. D. The age of a surviving manuscript is automatically the age of the original composition.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct and follows Upinder's description closely. B confuses manuscript culture with print, C ignores the commentarial layout described by Upinder, and D collapses copy date and composition date.

Q14. Which description of palm-leaf production is correct?

A. Leaves were cast in bronze moulds and stamped with movable type. B. Leaves were cut, pierced, strung, inscribed with a stylus and darkened with soot or charcoal mix to reveal the letters. C. Texts were painted only on silk cloth in the earliest phase. D. Palm leaves were unaffected by insects, water or fire.

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct because it summarises Upinder's material description. A is print-era fantasy, C narrows manuscript culture falsely, and D denies the very preservation problem that created copying traditions.

Q15. Which statement best captures a critical edition?

A. A critical edition destroys all variant readings so that one editor's preference becomes the text. B. A critical edition is only a government gazette notification. C. A critical edition compares manuscripts to identify common core and records variants in an apparatus. D. A critical edition means converting a script into spoken performance.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because a critical edition compares multiple manuscripts, reconstructs common readings and preserves variants in an apparatus. The other options turn textual criticism into censorship, gazette publication or performance conversion.

Q16. Which statement about colophons is safest?

A. A colophon means the script is definitely Brahmi. B. A colophon is identical to the Eighth Schedule. C. A colophon proves that no textual interpolation ever occurred. D. A colophon can carry transmission clues such as author, editor or scribal claims, but it should not be equated automatically with original composition date.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct because colophons can preserve transmission clues yet still cannot be treated as automatic proof of original composition date. The other options confuse colophons with script identity, constitutional categories or total textual certainty.

Q17. Which statement about Sangam literature is safest?

A. It is the earliest known literature of South India and is powerful but bounded evidence, not a complete dynastic chronicle. B. It contains no social or material references at all. C. It belongs wholly to Persian court culture. D. It can be dated to one undisputed year of publication.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct because it combines source value and caution. B ignores evidence on trade, war and society; C mislocates the corpus; D misreads a layered tradition as a single publication event.

Q18. Which pair is correctly matched in the Sangam bank?

A. Agam - outer public field of war and statecraft only B. Tolkappiyam - Tamil grammar and cultural classification text C. Pattuppattu - Perso-Arabic calligraphic style D. Vatakkirutal - Buddhist commentary on Vinaya rules

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct. Agam is the inner field, Pattuppattu belongs to the Ten Idylls corpus, and Vatakkirutal is a Sangam-age ritual practice rather than a Buddhist commentary.

Q19. Which statement about Vatakkirutal is safest?

A. It refers to a Deccan revenue script. B. It names a Mauryan law book. C. It denotes a Tamil ritual of fasting to death, especially linked in the source bank with honour after defeat. D. It is the title of Bhasa's best-known play.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct. The other three options confuse a Sangam cultural practice with script, statecraft or classical drama.

Q20. Which statement about classical Sanskrit authorship is safest?

A. Attribution questions should be answered by guessing the most famous poet. B. No Sanskrit dramatist is relevant to this topic. C. The 2024 Bhasa question was about an inscriptional script, not a literary work. D. Bhasa, Kalidasa, Shudraka, Bharavi, Dandin and Bhavabhuti belong to the dramatic-kavya-poetics bank, and author-work pairs must be checked carefully.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct because the safest rule in this bank is verification of the author-work pair rather than guessing by fame. The other options either invite lazy attribution or deny the obvious relevance of classical Sanskrit authorship to Topic 11.

Q21. Which work is safest to associate with the 2024 Bhasa attribution route?

A. Madhyama-vyayoga B. Mahabhashya C. Kavyalankara D. Natyashastra

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct because the official local 2024 key confirms Madhyama-vyayoga as the work attributed to Bhasa. Mahabhashya is Patanjali's grammatical work, Natyashastra is attributed to Bharata, and Kavyalankara belongs elsewhere in poetics.

Q22. Which statement best captures the Pallava literature route?

A. It depends only on saying that rulers supported literature. B. It is built through Dandin, bilingual Tamil-Sanskrit inscriptions, Kanchipuram's scholarly setting and Pallava-Grantha court use. C. It can be answered without any named evidence. D. It belongs only to modern Hindi print history.

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct. A and C are the very weaknesses the repair avoids, while D is unrelated chronologically and linguistically.

Q23. Which statement about Hindi's literary rise is safest?

A. Hindi was the official language of the Mauryan empire under Article 343. B. Hindi has no relation to Prakrit or Apabhramsha in the source bank. C. Hindi emerged through a long process involving Apabhramsha and received major literary momentum through Bhakti. D. Hindi literature began only after electronic media.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because the keyed statement captures Hindi's long emergence through Apabhramsha and its later literary expansion through Bhakti. The other options are anachronistic or deny the very transition the sources describe.

Q24. Which statement about Urdu is safest?

A. It is a foreign import with no Indian literary development. B. It can never be associated with Dakkani usage. C. Its script history is identical to Brahmi's. D. It is treated in the source bank as an Indo-Aryan language shaped through Persian-Hindi interaction within India.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct because Urdu is treated in the source bank as an Indo-Aryan language shaped in India through Persian-Hindi interaction. The other options either foreignise it, deny its Dakkani connection or confuse its script history with Brahmi.

Q25. Which pair is correctly matched?

A. Qaseeda - praise-oriented poetic form built around a single presiding subject B. Ginan - Mauryan copper-plate donation formula C. Shahr Ashob - Sangam love classification D. Nastaliq - palm-leaf preservation chemical

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct. Ginan refers to Nizari Ismaili devotional hymns, Shahr Ashob is an Urdu poetic genre of social-political anguish, and Nastaliq is a calligraphic hand rather than a preservation chemical.

Q26. Which statement about status categories is correct as checked on 6 September 2026?

A. India has only six classical languages because no later official revision occurred. B. India has 11 classical languages after the October 2024 additions of Marathi, Pali, Prakrit, Assamese and Bengali. C. Pali and Prakrit are Scheduled languages in the Eighth Schedule. D. Rajasthani is a classical language because it appears in Sahitya Akademi's award list.

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct because the official October 2024 notification raised the classical-language total to 11 by adding Marathi, Pali, Prakrit, Assamese and Bengali. The other choices freeze the earlier position or confuse classical

status with other ledgers.

Q27. Which statement distinguishes the Eighth Schedule most safely?

A. It is identical to the list of classical languages. B. It lists only the official language of the Union. C. It contains 22 Scheduled languages and should not be confused with classical-language status or with Sahitya Akademi's 24-language recognition field. D. It is a UNESCO documentary-heritage register.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because the Eighth Schedule lists 22 Scheduled languages and is not interchangeable with classical-language status or Sahitya Akademi's 24-language field. The other options confuse constitutional categories with UNESCO or with the Union's official language alone.

Q28. Which statement about Article 343 is safest in this topic?

A. It declares Sanskrit to be the national language of India. B. It creates the Sahitya Akademi award list. C. It added Marathi, Pali and Prakrit to the classical-language list in 2024. D. It says the official language of the Union shall be Hindi in Devanagari script; this is not the same as a national-language declaration.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct because Article 343 concerns the official language of the Union: Hindi in Devanagari script, not a national-language declaration. The other options misassign it to Sanskrit, Sahitya Akademi or the 2024 classical-language notification.

Q29. Which statement about Sahitya Akademi is safest?

A. Its 2023-24 annual report shows a 24-language award/working field, including English and Rajasthani in addition to the 22 Scheduled languages. B. Its language list is the same as the current classical-language list. C. It is the constitutional appendix that defines Article 343. D. It replaced the National Mission for Manuscripts in 2026.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct and is precisely why Topic 11 must separate institutional ledgers. B, C and D collapse unrelated bodies and functions.

Q30. Which statement about the Bakhshali manuscript is safest?

A. It is a palm-leaf Tamil medical manuscript from 1997. B. It is a birch-bark mathematical manuscript whose surviving copy is debated in date and should be separated from the older work it transmits. C. It is the same as the Charaka Samhita colophon tradition. D. It proves that every zero symbol in India first appears in 876 CE.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Under the required rotation B contains the correct Bakhshali caution in the authored ordering. The distractors confuse it with other manuscript traditions or flatten the chronology of zero evidence.

Q31. Which statement about place-value evidence is safest?

A. Zero, decimal notation and inscriptional evidence all appear in one uncontested moment and place. B. The topic has no connection with epigraphy. C. The question must be handled through dated evidence, including debated manuscript chronology, early Southeast Asian inscriptions and later Indian inscriptional milestones. D. A provisional 2026 key can be treated as final official proof in the workbook.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because the safest way to handle place-value history is through dated evidence, not through slogan-history or a provisional key. The other options flatten chronology, deny the epigraphic dimension or misuse provisional answer material.

Q32. Which statement about current manuscript policy is safest?

A. The survey automatically transfers ownership of manuscripts to the state. B. The survey is only a UNESCO site-management plan. C. The survey makes all manuscript dating disputes disappear. D. The Gyan Bharatam National Manuscript Survey launched on 16 March 2026 and follows identification, verification, metadata creation and conservation/digitisation stages.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct because the keyed statement describes the Gyan Bharatam survey accurately: identification, verification, metadata and conservation/digitisation. The other options invent ownership transfer, confuse the survey with a UNESCO site plan or pretend that cataloguing erases dating disputes.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED OBJECTIVE / APPLICATION PYQS

PYQ 1. CSE Prelims 2021 - Bhavabhuti, Hastimalla and Kshemeshvara

Question: With reference to the history of ancient India, Bhavabhuti, Hastimalla and Kshemeshvara were famous as (a) Jain monks (b) playwrights (c) temple architects (d) philosophers.

Answer withheld pending official UPSC key.

Concept analysis: This is an attribution trap from the drama-literature bank. Revise Bhavabhuti's dramatic corpus and remember that UPSC sometimes tests less frequently rehearsed Sanskrit/Jain dramatic names alongside better-known authors. Because the final official local key is not held in the repository, the workbook withholds the answer letter.

PYQ 2. CSE Prelims 2023 - Vattakirutal in Sangam poems

Question: Which one of the following explains the practice of 'Vattakirutal' as mentioned in Sangam poems? (a) Kings employing women bodyguards (b) Learned persons assembling in royal courts to discuss religious and philosophical matters (c) Young girls keeping watch over agricultural fields and driving away birds and animals (d) A king defeated in battle committing ritual suicide by starving himself to death.

Answer withheld pending official UPSC key.

Concept analysis: The concept tested is not generic 'Tamil custom' but a specific honour-and-defeat ritual in the Sangam cultural bank. The safest study route is to pair Vatakkirutal with Tolkappiyam, Agam-Puram classification and the social/public field of Sangam literature. No final local-official key is available here, so the answer letter is withheld.

PYQ 3. CSE Prelims 2024 - Work attributed to Bhasa

Question: Which one of the following is a work attributed to playwright Bhasa? (a) Kavyalankara (b) Natyashastra (c) Madhyama-vyayoga (d) Mahabhashya.

Answer: C.

Concept analysis: C is correct because the locally held official 2024 answer key marks Q63 as C.

Madhyama-vyayoga belongs to the Bhasa attribution route. Kavyalankara belongs to poetics, Natyashastra to Bharata's dramaturgic tradition, and Mahabhashya to grammatical commentary.

PYQ 4. CSE Prelims 2026 - Place-value system in India

Question: Consider the following statements relating to the use of the place-value system in India: (1) The earliest epigraphic use in India is found in the Mankani plates from Gujarat (AD 595-596). (2) In the ninth century, place-values become general in inscriptions all over India. (3) Place-values have been found in Sanskrit inscriptions in South-east Asia as early as the seventh century. Which of the statements given above are correct?

Answer withheld pending official UPSC key.

Concept analysis: This routed 2026 question tests dated numerical evidence, not slogan-history. Prepare the triad of debated manuscript chronology, early South-east Asian Sanskrit inscriptional evidence, and later Indian inscriptional milestones such as Gwalior. The repository holds only a provisional 2026 key, so no answer letter is printed.

VERIFIED DIRECT / APPLICATION MAINS PYQS

PYQ-M1. GS-I Mains 2024 (cross-owned application) - Pallavas of Kanchi

Question: Estimate the contribution of Pallavas of Kanchi for the development of art and literature of South India. (Answer in 150 words)

Model answer: The Pallavas of Kanchi shaped South Indian culture through a linked project of monument building, script choice and literary patronage. In art, the line from Mandagapattu's experimental rock-cut phase to Mamallapuram's rathas, open-air reliefs and Shore Temple shows the movement from excavation to structural confidence. In literature, their contribution is not a vague claim of patronage alone. Kanchipuram emerged as a centre of Sanskrit learning, Dandin is linked to the Pallava court, and bilingual Tamil-Sanskrit inscriptions from the seventh century onward show a consciously layered cultural order. The Pallava court's preference for Grantha over Vatteluttu in courtly usage further indicates script intervention as part of literary history. Thus Pallava contribution lies in joining temple, text and inscription into one durable South Indian civilisational zone, though court practice should not be exaggerated into total social uniformity.

Note: This question is cross-owned with Topics 03 and 07. The answer here emphasises the literature-script half while keeping the art line minimally complete.

ORIGINAL MAINS MODEL ANSWERS

Original Q1. 10 marks

Question: Distinguish language family, script, register and language status in the Indian context. Answer in about 150 words.

Model answer: Indian language questions become manageable only after the main axes are separated. A language family is genealogical: Indo-Aryan, Dravidian, Austroasiatic and Tibeto-Burman classify descent. A script is a writing system: Brahmi, Kharoshthi, Grantha, Sharada and Devanagari do not by themselves identify one family. A register refers to actual literary or social use - Sanskrit, Pali, Prakrit, Persian, Urdu and Tamil may function differently in ritual, court, canonical or public settings. Status is institutional: Article 343 covers the official language of the Union, the Eighth Schedule lists Scheduled languages, classical-language status is conferred by the Union government on separate criteria, and Sahitya Akademi uses its own 24-language working field. Thus the best answer begins by separating the categories and only then attaching examples; otherwise the candidate mistakes genealogy for constitutional recognition or script for speech community.

Original Q2. 10 marks

Question: Why must a historian distinguish composition date, manuscript date and edition date while using literary sources? Answer in about 150 words.

Model answer: A literary text survives through transmission, not as a frozen original. The Vedas, epics, Sangam corpus, Charaka Samhita or Bakhshali manuscript all show that formation, copying and preservation occur at different times. A surviving manuscript may be much later than the work it preserves; the Bakhshali manuscript is the clearest example because its surviving birch-bark copy is debated in date while the mathematical material transmitted through it is older. Colophons, commentaries and scribal notes can add clues, but they do not collapse copy date into original composition. A critical edition is later still: it compares multiple manuscripts and records variants. If these distinctions are ignored, the historian converts textual transmission into false chronology. Therefore composition date, manuscript witness, discovery date and modern edition must be treated as separate historical facts.

Original Q3. 15 marks

Question: Examine the coexistence of Sanskrit, Pali, Prakrit and Apabhramsha in Indian literary history. Answer in about 250 words.

Model answer: Indian literary history is a field of coexistence and gradual transition rather than sharp replacement. Sanskrit, systematised through Panini's grammatical tradition, became the major codified language of elite learning, court poetry and many dramatic texts. Yet the Middle Indo-Aryan field simultaneously produced Pali and the literary Prakrits. Pali became central to the Theravada canonical world; Ardhamagadhi gained special importance in Jain textual tradition; Shauraseni and Maharashtri entered dramatic and literary usage. Nitin explicitly warns that transitions between languages and dialects were slow, which means a civilisational story built on one language replacing another is misleading. Apabhramsha then forms a bridge zone between Middle and New Indo-Aryan, eventually feeding later vernacular literary publics. The Bhakti expansion later widened Hindi and other regional-language literature without eliminating Sanskrit or Persian overnight. The best answer therefore highlights division of labour: Sanskrit for codification and courtly expression, Pali and Prakrit for canonical and public-textual roles, Apabhramsha for transition, and vernaculars for widening audiences. The needed qualification is that literary label, spoken language and social reach never map perfectly onto one another.

Original Q4. 15 marks

Question: Assess Sangam literature as a historical source for early South India. Answer in about 250 words.

Model answer: Sangam literature is among the richest literary sources for early South India, but it must be used with evidentiary discipline. The corpus preserved through Ettuthokai and Pattuppattu, along with Tolkappiyam and later Tamil epics, illuminates love, war, trade, ports, urban life, social ranking, landscape classification, bardic culture and rituals such as Vatakkiruttal. Its Agam-Puram distinction alone shows that the literary order already recognised different interior and public worlds. Nitin's book also notes women poets, named rulers and the cultural role of Madurai-centred assemblies. However, R.S. Sharma's caution is indispensable: Sangam literature is powerful but bounded evidence. It was composed and compiled over a long period; the first two Sangams are partly legendary in later tradition; and the corpus does not function as a neat dynastic chronicle. Therefore the historian should use it to reconstruct social, economic and cultural life rather than to derive an uninterrupted year-by-year political history. The best answer closes with this balance: source-rich, regionally foundational, but chronologically layered and genre-conditioned.

Original Q5. 20 marks

Question: Discuss the significance of script history and epigraphy in reconstructing India's cultural past. Answer in about 300 words.

Model answer: Script history matters because inscriptions are among the most securely dated public records of the past. Epigraphy studies inscriptions, while palaeography studies old writing. Together they allow the historian to track state communication, patronage, linguistic change, religious donation and regional power. Harappan script reminds us of the limit case: without decipherment, interpretation remains bounded. The Ashokan archive provides the opposite case - a large deciphered corpus, mostly in Prakrit and Brahmi, with Kharoshthi in the north-west and Greek-Aramaic evidence in the frontier zone. This distribution alone reveals a multilingual political field. Modern decipherment is itself part of historiography: James Prinsep's 1837 breakthrough on Mauryan Brahmi and later correlation with Piyadasi-Ashoka evidence transformed Indian history-writing. Later script histories - Grantha in the Tamil-Kerala sphere, Sharada in Kashmir, Gurmukhi in Sikh textual standardisation, Modi in Marathi administration, Nandinagari in South Indian Sanskrit manuscripts - show that scripts are shaped by use, not merely by abstract lineage. Epigraphy also disciplines chronology. Panini's grammatical antiquity and Rudradaman's Junagarh inscription answer different questions; the Chebrolu inscription anchors South Indian datable Sanskrit epigraphy; and place-value inscriptions

show numerical history moving through manuscripts and inscriptions across regions. Thus script history is not decorative philology. It is a key route to dated evidence, regional variation and the material conditions of literary culture.

Original Q6. 20 marks

Question: How should India protect manuscript heritage while avoiding simplistic cultural claims? Answer in about 300 words.

Model answer: Manuscript protection requires both civilisational commitment and historical caution. The first task is material: manuscripts on palm leaf, birch bark, paper or mixed media deteriorate through heat, insects, fungus, water, fire and handling. Upinder's preservation notes - fumigation, cleaning, repair, oiling, restringing and careful storage - show that conservation begins with the object. The second task is documentary: cataloguing, metadata, script identification, language identification, colophon reading and digitisation convert a private or fragile object into usable historical evidence. The third task is intellectual: critical editions and comparative study must distinguish the age of a surviving manuscript from the age of the work it preserves. This is crucial in cases such as the Bakhshali manuscript or layered medical texts. The fourth task is institutional. The Ministry of Culture's Gyan Bharatam mission and the 16 March 2026 National Manuscript Survey use a four-stage route of identification, physical verification, detailed metadata and conservation/digitisation, while explicitly stating that reporting manuscripts does not transfer ownership. Finally, cultural claims must remain disciplined. Not every old manuscript proves one timeless national essence; some are religious, some medical, some mathematical, some administrative, some multilingual. The strongest answer therefore combines conservation policy with source criticism and treats manuscript heritage as plural, fragile and historically layered rather than as a slogan.